

On the move

Your legs are the longest, strongest, and heaviest parts of your body. They need to be, since they hold you upright when you stand still and also provide the power to make you move. At the same time, your feet form a secure base, which supports your body weight, and push against the ground to help you walk or run.

FAST OR SLOW

Moving around on two legs requires strength. Much of the power comes from the thigh and buttock muscles, which also help keep you balanced when one foot is off the ground. Leg muscles are a mixture of fast fibers that can produce quick bursts of speed and slow fibers that work for longer periods without tiring.

The Achilles tendon—a tough ropelike strap—attaches the calf muscle to the heel bone, enabling you to stand on your toes.

The muscles running along the sole move your toes and help cushion your foot.

The thinner lower leg bone is called the fibula.

Your hamstring muscles pull the thigh back and bend the knee.

This muscle lifts the foot upward and supports the foot arch when you walk or run.

This long muscle straightens your toes.

Your calf muscle bends your foot downward.

The shinbone (tibia) is the largest bone in the lower leg.

The big toe has two bones—unlike the other toes, which have three bones each.

These long, thin sole bones form the arch of the foot.

The ankle bones work together to provide stability.

Sticking out from the back of the foot is your heel bone, the largest bone in your foot.

FOOT WORK

The bony framework of your foot is stronger but less flexible than your hand because it has to support your body weight. Each foot has 26 bones—14 toe bones, five sole bones, and seven ankle bones.

- Ankle bones
- Sole bones
- Toe bones